

EMPOWERING FAMILIES: ENHANCING SOCIAL SUPPORT FOR CHILD REARING AND FAMILY PLANNING IN JAPAN

Anonymous authors

Paper under double-blind review

ABSTRACT

This paper investigates the critical role of social support in child-rearing and its influence on family planning decisions in Japan, a country facing significant challenges due to declining birth rates. The complexity of balancing work and child-rearing responsibilities is exacerbated by inadequate social support systems. We propose targeted policies, including housing subsidies to enable families to live near their extended families and increased paternity leave for fathers, to enhance social support. Insights from interviews with experts and working parents underscore the necessity of community support, flexible policies, and positive societal attitudes to improve family dynamics and child-rearing practices.

1 INTRODUCTION

This paper investigates the critical role of social support in child-rearing and its influence on family planning decisions in Japan, a country facing significant challenges due to declining birth rates. Understanding how social support systems influence the decision to raise children is crucial for addressing these demographic issues and promoting family well-being.

Japan's declining birth rates pose significant challenges to the country's economic and social stability. Social support systems, including family, community, and governmental support, play a critical role in influencing family planning decisions. However, these systems in Japan are often inadequate or poorly implemented, making it difficult for families to balance work and child-rearing responsibilities. This inadequacy creates a significant barrier to increasing birth rates and improving family well-being.

To address these challenges, we propose several policies to enhance social support for families, including housing subsidies to enable families to live near their extended families and increased paternity leave for fathers. These policies aim to alleviate the burden on families and create a more supportive environment for child-rearing.

To gain a deeper understanding of the issues and potential solutions, we conducted interviews with experts and working parents. These interviews provided valuable insights into the lived experiences of families and the effectiveness of current social support systems.

Our contributions are as follows:

- We provide a comprehensive analysis of the role of social support in child-rearing and family planning decisions in Japan.
- We propose specific policies to enhance social support for families, including housing subsidies and increased paternity leave.
- We present insights from interviews with experts and working parents, highlighting the importance of community support, flexible policies, and societal attitudes.

Future work will focus on further refining these policies and exploring additional measures to support families in Japan. We will also continue to gather data from a

broader range of stakeholders to ensure that our recommendations are inclusive and effective.